Nursing Essentials

Priority: Use the exposure history, prenatal testing, and newborn findings to guide targeted evaluation; TORCH is a memory aid, not one universal panel.

FOCUS 1

Prevent exposure

- **Toxoplasma prevention:** cook meat thoroughly; use food / soil hygiene and precautions around cat litter.
- **CMV prevention:** wash hands after contact with young children's saliva or urine; avoid sharing utensils or mouth-to-mouth kissing.
- **Possible effects:** congenital infection can affect hearing, vision, growth, or neurologic development; findings may be delayed.

FOCUS 2

Assess risk

- **Rubella:** verify immunity. Live MMR vaccine is avoided during pregnancy; offer postpartum vaccination when indicated.
- **HSV at labor:** active genital lesions or prodrome changes the birth plan; cesarean is generally recommended in that setting.
- **Newborn HSV:** illness may be severe without obvious skin lesions; concerning symptoms require urgent evaluation.

FOCUS 3

Treat specifically

- **Syphilis:** prenatal screening and timely treatment protect the fetus; follow current repeat-testing guidance and local requirements.
- **HIV / hepatitis B:** maternal treatment and specific newborn prevention plans depend on confirmed status and current protocols.
- **Exposure-based risks:** varicella, parvovirus B19, and others require targeted assessment rather than assumptions from the acronym.

Newborn assessment and follow-up

Make it stick: A normal newborn appearance does not exclude congenital infection. Prenatal history, appropriate testing, and follow-up complete the assessment.

Focus	What to know	Nursing application
Possible clues	growth restriction, petechiae, jaundice, hepatosplenomegaly, abnormal head size, or eye / hearing findings.	Assess the full picture
Testing timing matters	for example, testing for congenital CMV generally must occur within the first 21 days to establish congenital infection.	Collect tests on time
Coordinate	ordered testing, infection-control measures, treatment, and developmental / hearing follow-up.	Arrange follow-up

RED FLAGS · ESCALATE PROMPTLY

A newborn with vesicles, seizures, respiratory distress, poor feeding, jaundice with illness, or abnormal perfusion needs urgent evaluation.